



Course: Online Journalism

Lec #2

Socio-economic, legal, cultural, and political issues related to the access of information through the Internet

Various socioeconomic, legal, cultural, and political issues can influence access to information through the Internet.

Socio-economic Issues:

People from lower-income backgrounds may not have the money to afford internet access, devices like smartphones or computers, or data plans. This is called the digital divide—the gap between those who have access to technology and those who do not. This can limit their ability to get information online, affecting education, job opportunities, and access to important services.

Example: In developing countries like **India** and **Nigeria**, rural communities frequently face poor internet infrastructure and high data costs, limiting their ability to engage with online news. This creates an information gap between urban and rural populations

Legal Issues:

Laws about internet access and online information vary by country. For example, some governments impose internet censorship, blocking access to certain websites or information. Privacy laws (like GDPR in Europe) also affect what information can be shared or accessed online. Without payment, intellectual property laws can limit access to certain content, like music, videos, or academic papers.

Example: In **China**, the government has implemented the **Great Firewall**, which restricts access to many international news sites and online platforms. Journalists working online must navigate strict regulations and censorship laws, limiting access to uncensored information.

The European Union's **Copyright Directive** requires platforms like **Google** and **Facebook** to pay publishers for snippets of news content shared online. This has led to tension between tech companies and publishers over fair compensation for journalistic content.

Cultural Issues:

Language and cultural differences can affect access to information. If most information online is in languages that a person doesn't understand, or if certain cultural views or practices are not represented, they may find it harder to engage. Cultural norms can also impact what is considered acceptable or inappropriate content online.



Example: Many international news websites, including **BBC** and **CNN**, produce the majority of their content in English, reducing accessibility for populations who primarily speak other languages. While some outlets offer content in multiple languages, coverage may be limited or translated versions may not be as timely or comprehensive.

During the 2016 U.S. presidential election, **Russian bots** and **troll farms** spread disinformation across social media platforms to influence public opinion. This misinformation affected cultural perceptions of political figures and events and influenced global discourse on U.S. politics.

In countries like **Saudi Arabia** and **Iran**, conservative cultural values shape strict regulations on what can be published online. Cultural taboos around criticism of religion or the government mean that access to certain types of journalism is heavily restricted.

Political Issues:

In some countries, governments **control** or heavily **influence** internet access, limiting what kind of political content people can **see**. Internet censorship or surveillance by the government can restrict freedom of speech and access to unbiased information, **especially** on political matters. In extreme cases, governments may shut down the internet entirely during political unrest or protests to control information.

Example: Turkey has increasingly cracked down on independent journalism, especially following the 2016 coup attempt. Many online news sites have been blocked or taken down, and journalists have been arrested for publishing content critical of the government. **Reporters Without Borders** ranks Turkey low in its World Press Freedom Index due to these practices.

In Saudi Arabia, journalist Jamal Khashoggi was murdered in 2018, after years of critical online writing about the Saudi regime. The state has also employed sophisticated digital tools to monitor and repress dissenting voices online.